



POLICY BRIEF

PHASING OUT ASBESTOS IN INDIA: AN ACTION PLAN FOR HEALTH PROTECTION AND SUSTAINABLE TRANSITION BY 2030

Executive Summary:

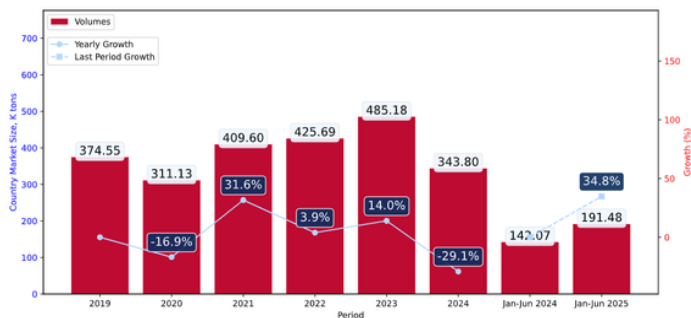
- Asbestos usage in India is alarming, a very severe health concern for its citizens and environments, especially chrysotile cement roofing and asbestos pipes.
- India imports more than ~3 to 4 lakh tonnes of asbestos each year. Despite the domestic asbestos mining ban in India.
- Exposing asbestos-related diseases (ARDs) like mesothelioma and lung cancer to informal recyclers, workers, and communities.
- Projected around 6 million people are going to be affected by the ARDs in the next 20-40 years.
- The existing rules, such as the 2024 Quality Control Order, the Factories Act, 1948, and Model Rules, Hazardous Waste Rules, and NGT's 2025 orders, only control the use of asbestos but do not completely ban it. Zero enforcement in the informal sector and no plan for transition in the industrial sectors.
- This policy brief recommends a gradual phaseout by 2030. Asbestos ban in new public projects by 2027, give subsidy to alternatives, mandate retraining of workers, strengthen regulatory frameworks by the MoEFCC with enforcement by the state pollution control board.
- The International Labour Organization (ILO)/ Basel Convention commitments India can achieve, and can reduce asbestos-related diseases by 50-70%, and sustainable, climate-resilient buildings will be promoted.

Introduction:

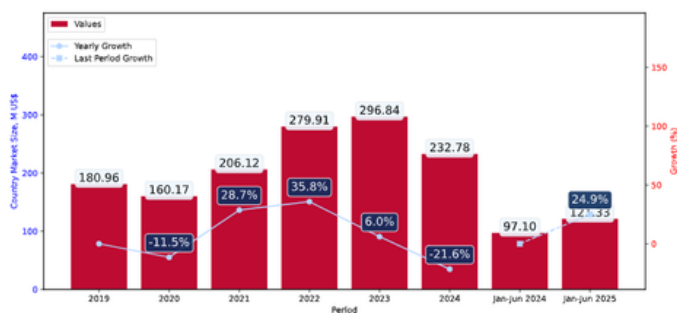
India faces a massive asbestos crisis that threatens public health and sustainability. Each year India imports 3.4 lakh tonnes plus of chrysotile asbestos, mainly cement roofing sheets, and pipes, despite a ban on asbestos mining in the 1980s (Singh & Frank, 2023). Millions of factory workers, scrap/demolition workers, slum communities, and school and public buildings have been exposed to various high-risk diseases like lung cancer, mesothelioma, and asbestosis, whose incubation can happen for up to 20-40 years, which means crores of people are going to be affected in the upcoming years (Subramanian & Madhavan, 2005) (Reporter, 2025). The Tata Institute warns more than 6 million people could have ARDs and 6 lakhs cancer cases (Reporter, 2025). The healthcare system may collapse due to a lack of palliative care (Jadhav & Gawde, 2019). Asbestos is not only a health issue, but also a challenge to climate-resilience housing (Singh & Frank, 2023). Asbestos sheets pose a significant health risk in flood-prone areas because they can contaminate soil and water (Whitmer, 2026). According to the Global Trade Algorithmic Intelligence Center (GTAIC), India is the world's top importer of asbestos, ~52% global market share (India Asbestos Imports by Country | 2022 | Data, n.d.), whereas 62+ countries have fully banned asbestos (Current Asbestos Bans, 2025).



GTAIC: India's import of asbestos, tonnes:

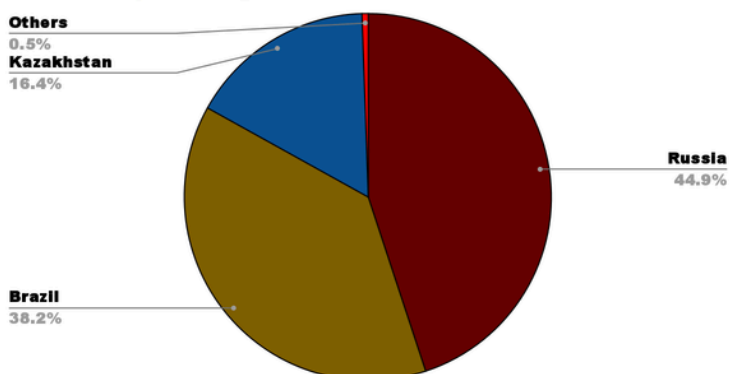


GTAIC: India's import of asbestos, US\$:



GTAIC:

The largest exporters of asbestos to India



- India is the largest importer of asbestos in the world. India imported worlds 52.1% asbestos alone in 2024. It means for every 2 tonnes of asbestos imported in the world, India imported 1 tonne of asbestos (Indian Minerals Yearbook, 2022) (GTAIC).
- In 2024, the total value of imports was US\$232.78 million, which is 343.8 thousand Ktones asbestos imported, as compared to the previous year, showing a negative growth 129.1% (GTAIC).
- From the first half of fiscal year 2025, India again surprisingly increased its import growth rate of 34.8%. Which indicates that the use of asbestos in India is steadily increasing. If it goes in same pace, the projected growth will reached 404Ktones in 2026 (GTAIC).





Impact of asbestos on human health

- According to the WHO, all types of asbestos (white asbestos/chrysotile) are carcinogenic(cancer-causing) (Asbestos, 2024).
- The people who work in the construction industry get more exposure to asbestos. Globally, more than 2 lakh deaths occur because of occupational asbestos exposure. These deaths represent more than 70 % of work-related cancer (World Health Organization: WHO, 2024) .
- Nearly 1500+ occupational mesothelioma victims have been identified in India. 6000+ confirmed asbestosis cases have been reported in Indian workers, mainly in AC sheet factories, demolition sites, and brake lining plants (“Asbestos in India: A Common Hazard,” 2022) .
- 2000+ mesothelioma deaths are projected every year according to the WHO/ILO formula (World Health Organization & International Labour Organization, 2021) .
- The workers who work in these asbestos factories have a 20-60% workers chance of having lung damage, which will lead to mesothelioma (Singh & Frank, 2026) .
- Thousands of workers have been dying annually, and crores will be identified because of 20-40 year latency in the future (Singh & Frank, 2026) .

Impact of asbestos on the environment

- Asbestos is not only a health hazard, but it's a permanent environmental pollution that can contaminate soil, water, and air (Stadelmann, 2025) .
- Non-biodegradable asbestos fibres can stay 100+ years in soil and can contaminate the crops (Macher et al., 2025) .
- Breaking of AC sheets and asbestos roofing releases fibers and causes significant environmental damage (Whitmer, 2025) .
- Improper disposal of asbestos in landfills can lead to contamination of the environment (Quarmby, 2024).
- Scrap workers demolish sheets without any protection in Urban slums, due to which risk of health issues and to the atmosphere (Li et al., 2023) .

Existing policies were used in the past to address this problem:

There is no comprehensive ban on asbestos in India, though mining is prohibited since 2011.

The chrysotile(white) asbestos is still legal, and it has been widely used in cement roofing sheets and pipes. The government's approach is not focused on a total ban, but on controlled use and safety standards.

- The Ministry of environment have clearly said that there is no prohibition on asbestos use.
- Under the Factories Act, 1948, and IS 11451:1986, it is defined as required to undergo mandatory wet processing so that asbestos fibres can not be released into the atmosphere. And regular health check-ups are compulsory for the workers.
- MoEFCC(Ministry of Environmental, Forest, and Climate Change) grants asbestos-based products environmental clearance under the EIA Notification,2006
- Disposal of asbestos waste is regulated through Hazardous and Other Waste under the Transboundary Movement and Management rules 2016.
- The National Green Tribunal(NGT) has given directions recently to make a policy to phase out asbestos from public schools (Peopels Training & Research Centre (PTRC) et al., n.d.) .

Despite national health concerns and the WHO's repeated warnings, India is still a major consumer of asbestos in the world. India's policies focus mainly on economic considerations, safe handling, and controlled use instead of a health-based total ban (Singh & Frank, 2023) .

Policy Options :

1. Major focus on current rules(2024 QCO, Factories Act Limits) and their proper implementations on the ground.
 - Increase State Pollution Control Board inspections and monthly raids. Build more infrastructure and services from the penalty fund. Improve proper medical facilities for workers' health and allocate future compensation.
 - Proper monitoring in these three areas, such as quality control, exposure monitoring, and waste disposal.

This option needs only(100-200 crores) less funding from the annual budget; industry disruptions will be minimal because AC sheet production will be continued. Implementation can be fast in the nation.

2. Gradual Phaseout by 2030: By 2027, works will be on public buildings, and by 2030, a complete phaseout in the country.
 - Import quotas cut yearly 20%.
 - Keep Sufficient Fund and give a 50% subsidy on alternatives
 - Train workers under the Skill India scheme.
 - And mandate green procurement in government projects.

The main advantage of this phase are it balances health protection and economic transitions perfectly, because 68 countries successfully phased out asbestos (Current Asbestos Bans, 2025b) . The existing mechanism like Skill India training and green budget funding (Cabinet Approves Continuation and Restructuring of Skill India Program), can help to implement this gradual phase out. According to experts, 50-70% asbestos related diseases can be controlled (Asbestos, 2024b).

3. Total Ban of asbestos: This approach will be zero tolerance, where exactly within 1 year, asbestos import and use will be completely banned. The emergency ordinance will be issued like (ban on single-use plastic). A specific compensation fund will be allocated for the workers and factories, and a crash production program will be launched where the alternative of fibre cement capacity will be doubled by government subsidy.

- The Ministry of Environment, Forest, and Climate Change will issue an immediate gazette notification.
- From day 1 complete ban on asbestos, existing stock in factories will be cleared within 6 months through a special amnesty scheme.
- The import holder's license will be suspended and FIR under the Hazardous Waste Rules.
- A compensation package will be provided to the workers and factories. Per workers Rs 2 lakh one-time amount, which is equivalent to 3 years' average salary. And 50 cr from the factory closure grant.

From this approach, the fastest health protection can be assured, and 6 million health cases can be completely prevented. India will become a global leadership signal in ILO Convention 162 and Basel Convention compliance (UNEP & Secretariat of the Basel Convention, 2003) . This approach will help long-term savings from future healthcare costs and industries will be ESG compliant (Lin et al., 2019) .

Final policy recommendation:

Gradual phase out by 2030 will be best to tackle this problem. Because It perfectly balances both health protection and economic transitions, and without creating any further crisis, it fills the current policy gaps.

- This similar phaseout of asbestos is used by 68 countries in the world. Countries like UK, Australia, and Japan have all proposed a 3-5 year timeline. Economic crisis could have been possible, but with gradual phaseout approach, smoothly transition happened.
- This is India ready approach because there is no need to create a new system, already India has schemes like Skill India, where already 1 crore plus workers is trained yearly.
- In the green budget, 10k crore+ fund is available for the sustainability projects. Just need a simple ordinance from MoEFCC. There is no requirement for a new ministry, no bureaucracy (Sinha, 2026)
- The government needs to intervene and give clear direction to execute this recommendation.
- The AC sheet industry will get 4 years(2026-2030) to build new fibre cement plants and to convert the existing machinery. Workers will be retrained through Skill India courses.
- A sudden ban can create a panic situation, but within 4 years smooth transition will be achieved (Lahav, 2026) .

Instruments to be adopted:

- The Ministry of Environment, Forest, and Climate Change(MoEFCC) official gazette notification will be issued, and all public buildings, schools, and hospitals will be completely banned by 2027. Complete ban on import and manufacturing of asbestos by 2030 nationwide. This ordinance will be created under the Factories Act and EP Act by the lens of the Supreme court enforceable.
- Specific Rs 10,000 Cr National Asbestos Transition Fund will be allocated, and 50% subsidy on alternatives, and also 1 lakh/per worker for retraining grant.
- Proper Monitoring by NGT on compliance report from MoEFCC(Factory Conversions, import data, and workers training progress. Every state's Pollution Control Board has to manage real time dashboard (Amita Bhaduri, 2025).

Implementation Structure:

- The Ministry of Environment, Forest, and Climate Change will lead the entire system. Its role is to design policy, the national road map, and phase-out ordinance notification.
- State Pollution Control Boards (SPCBs) will enforce the policy. Its role is to inspect factories, ensure proper monitoring, and industries compliance certificates. Fines on non-compliant factories and manage the real-time data dashboard
- Ministry of Labour and Skill India will provide proper training and deliver training certificates, and ensure reemployment in green jobs.
- Ministry of Finance will allocate 10cr National asbestos fund with green bonds.
- Ministry of Information and Broadcasting (MIB) will be aware India's citizens through National campaigns about the risk, safe disposal, and alternative materials.

Detailed Timeline;

- Phase 1 will be the preparation phase, where all ordinance notifications, budget allocation, and R&D subsidies will be considered. By 2026
- Phase 2 will be the pilot phase, where public buildings/schools ban asbestos, and an awareness campaign will happen by 2027
- Phase 3 will be Scale up phase, where 50% projects will be asbestos-free, and 50k workers will be retrained by 2028-2029
- Phase 4 will be a full ban phase when complete prohibition on import/use and 100% industries' compliance audits by 2030 onwards.



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